

Palmistry

PDAs offer you computing that's mobile, cheap, and they look really cool too. We take a look at the best available in the market, so that you can make the right choice

Personal Digital Assistants (PDAs) or handheld computers are becoming mainstream faster than some of us believe. Though the rate of evolution has not been as fast as compared to that of mobile phones, as seen in the last few years, PDA vendors have recognised the evolving needs of consumers, and have tried to keep pace by launching feature-rich models that cater to various usage patterns. This gets us back to the very critical question of why anyone would require a PDA. Sure, you could get one if you have the money, and put your cellphone to shame. However, apart from their enormous flaunt value, PDAs can do a lot of very useful tasks that make them worthy of possession.

Current models can do much more than store hundreds of your contacts and text notes—they can get you organised, entertain you by playing games, music and video clips, and exchange data wirelessly. Some can even take photographs and make phone calls. Convergence of various technologies in the mobile segment has converted the traditional PDA to a versatile secretary, maybe more. It's not uncommon to come across hybrid devices such as the Sony Ericsson P800 that offer the combined functionalities of a mobile phone, a PDA and a camera, all rolled into one swanky package.

The big players such as Dell, HP Compaq, Toshiba, Sony, Sharp and Palm, all have a slew of models catering to various user requirements and run different platforms such as Palm OS, Linux and Microsoft Pocket PC. Though not many vendors sell PDAs officially in India at the moment, the grey market is always happy to oblige. If not, you

can always ask your US-based cousin to get one for you. This month we look at some of the main platforms available for PDAs, the kind of applications you can run on them, and some of the devices running on these platforms.



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